Chapter 3: Advanced Features of Writer

Table of Contents (ToC), Templates, Track Changes & Document Reviewing (Session 2026-2027)

1. Table of Contents (ToC) & Heading Hierarchy

A **Table of Contents (ToC)** is an organized list or table placed at the beginning of a book, document, or project report that displays chapter titles, section headings, and subheadings alongside their commencing page numbers.

Hierarchy of Headings

By **hierarchy of headings**, we mean clearly organized, tiered levels of headings where higher levels correspond to major divisions and lower levels represent granular sub-sections:

- **Level 1 (Heading 1):** Primary titles, main unit titles, or book chapters.
- **Level 2 (Heading 2):** Sub-topics and sections within a Level 1 chapter.
- **Level 3 (Heading 3):** Sub-subsections and sub-topics within a Level 2 section.
- **LibreOffice Default Scope:** LibreOffice Writer evaluates up to **10 levels of headings** (`Heading 1` through `Heading 10`) by default when compiling a Table of Contents.

> **Why Use Automated ToC Instead of Manual Typing? [CBSE Board Rationale]**
> 1. **Automated Accuracy:** Page numbers and heading names are extracted programmatically, preventing numbering and typographical mistakes.
> 2. **One-Click Maintenance:** Any change in document structure, heading wording, or page length is updated with a single click.
> 3. **Interactive Hyperlinks:** Every ToC entry functions as a clickable hyperlink (`Ctrl + Click`), immediately jumping readers to that location in the document.

Structure of a Standard ToC Entry

A typical generated ToC entry line consists of four main components:

1. **Chapter/Section Number:** The hierarchical numeral prefix (e.g., *1.2*).
2. **Entry Text:** The actual heading text copied from the document.
3. **Tab Leader Character:** A dotted (or dashed/solid) line filling the horizontal blank space between the entry text and page number.
4. **Page Number:** The exact page on which that heading begins.

2. Creating, Customizing & Managing a ToC

Step-by-Step Procedure to Insert a Table of Contents

1. Apply appropriate heading styles (`Heading 1`, `Heading 2`, etc.) to all titles and section headings across your document.
2. Position the blinking text cursor at the exact location where the ToC should appear (usually on a blank page following the title page).
3. Select **Insert > Table of Contents and Index > Table of Contents, Index or Bibliography...** from the Menu bar.
4. In the dialog that appears, verify settings in the **Type** tab (Title, Type, and Evaluation levels).
5. Click **OK**. The ToC generates instantly.

> **Exam Troubleshooting Point [CBSE SQP 2025-26]:** If a newly inserted Table of Contents appears completely blank, the most common reason is that the author **forgot to apply paragraph heading styles** (`Heading 1`, `Heading 2`, etc.) to the document headings, leaving them formatted as regular body text.

The 5 Tabs of the Table of Contents Dialog Box [CBSE SQP 2023-24]

Tab Name	Functional Scope & Key Settings
1. Type	Sets the title of the ToC (default: "Table of Contents"), document scope (entire document or specific chapter), number of heading levels evaluated (up to 10), and the *Protected against manual changes* checkbox.
2. Entries	Configures how entry items on each level appear using the interactive **Structure line** (`E#` Chapter Number, `E` Entry Text, `T` Tab Stop, `#` Page Number, `LS` Link Start, `LE` Link End). Allows applying specific Character Styles to individual components.
3. Styles	Assigns different paragraph styles to each ToC evaluation level to modify typography and indentation.
4. Columns	Enables displaying the Table of Contents in multiple columns (e.g., 2 or 3 columns) with custom column width and spacing.
5. Background	Applies a custom background fill to the ToC block, such as a solid color or an imported graphic/image.

Note: The dialog contains only these 5 tabs. Tabs like "Row" or "Table" do NOT exist.

Maintaining / Updating and Deleting a ToC

- **Updating a ToC:** LibreOffice Writer does **not** update the ToC automatically when headings or page counts change. To refresh it: Right-click anywhere inside the generated ToC and select **Update Index**.
- **Deleting a ToC:** Right-click anywhere inside the generated ToC and select **Delete Index**. The table is removed immediately.
- **Editing Properties:** Right-click inside the ToC and select **Edit Index** to reopen the 5-tab dialog.

3. Document Templates in LibreOffice Writer

A **Template** is a pre-designed "blueprint" or master document that contains predefined formatting rules, styles (paragraph, character, page), layout properties, headers, footers, logos, tables, and macros. New documents created from a template inherit all of its formatting automatically without altering the original master template file.

Core Advantages of Templates [CBSE Board 2023, SQP 2022-23]:

- **Standardization & Consistency:** Guarantees uniform brand appearance across company reports, invoices, letterheads, and notices.
- **Time & Effort Savings:** Eliminates the repetitive manual setup of headers, legal footers, margins, and styles from scratch.
- **Error Reduction:** Preserves required structural elements so authors only need to insert new text.

File Extensions & Management Shortcuts

- **Template File Extension:** `.ott` (OpenDocument Text Template). Standard Writer document is `.odt`.
- **Templates Dialog Shortcut:** `Ctrl + Shift + N` (or menu **File > Templates > Manage Templates**).

Complete Step-by-Step Practical Procedures for Templates

A. Creating a Template from a Document [CBSE Board 2024: Two Ways to Create]

1. Open a new or existing Writer document and configure all desired formatting, fonts, margins, headers, company logo, and styles.
2. Choose **File > Templates > Save as Template...** from the Menu bar.
3. In the *Save As Template* dialog box:
   - Type a name for the new template in the *Template Name* field.
   - Select an appropriate template category (e.g., *My Templates*, *Business Correspondence*).
   - (Optional) Check the **Set as default template** checkbox if desired.
4. Click **Save**. The custom template is stored in the user templates repository.

B. Creating a Document Using Predefined / In-Built Templates

1. Choose **File > New > Templates...** (or press `Ctrl + Shift + N`).
2. In the *Templates* dialog, select the desired category filter (e.g., *Documents*).
3. Double-click the template thumbnail (or select it and click **Open**).
4. A new, untitled document (`Untitled 1`) containing the template layout opens, ready for editing.

C. Using Online Templates

1. Open the Templates dialog (`Ctrl + Shift + N`).
2. Click the **Manage** dropdown at the top-right and select **Extensions**.
3. Browse the online extensions window, locate the desired template, and click the link to open the official download page.
4. Download the template file and double-click to install it into LibreOffice.

D. Importing a Template

1. Choose **File > Templates > Manage Templates** (`Ctrl + Shift + N`).
2. Click the **Manage** button at the top-right and select **Import**.
3. Select the category folder where the imported template should reside, then click **OK**.
4. In the file browser, locate the `.ott` template file on your computer/network and click **Open**.

E. Moving a Template Between Categories [CBSE Board Set-4]

1. Open the Templates dialog (`Ctrl + Shift + N`).
2. Locate and right-click on the template thumbnail you wish to relocate.
3. Select **Move** from the context menu.
4. In the *Select Category* dialog, choose the target category folder (or click *Create New Category*) and click **OK**.

F. Exporting a Template [CBSE Board Set-4 Q.17]

Exporting saves a template file out of the internal LibreOffice template management directory into a standard external folder on your computer or USB drive, making it shareable via email or removable media.

1. Open the Templates dialog by selecting **File > Templates > Manage Templates** (`Ctrl + Shift + N`).
2. Locate and right-click the template you wish to export.
3. Select **Export** from the context menu.
4. In the *Select Folder* browser, navigate to the target external folder on your disk and click **Select Folder**.

> **Moving vs. Exporting a Template:** *Moving* changes the internal organization category folder within LibreOffice Writer without saving an external copy. *Exporting* writes a physical `.ott` file to an external disk path so it can be shared or backed up.

G. Setting and Resetting the Default Template [CBSE SQP 2022-23]

- **Set as Default:** Open Templates dialog (`Ctrl + Shift + N`) > Right-click the desired template > Select **Set as Default**. All subsequent new documents (`Ctrl + N`) will open based on this template.
- **Reset to Default:** Open Templates dialog > Click the **Manage** button > Select **Reset Default Template > Text Document**.

4. Track Changes & Document Reviewing

In collaborative environments (co-authoring reports, academic papers, and editorial reviews), multiple contributors review and edit the same file. The **Track Changes** feature records every alteration made to the document so the primary owner can review them and decide whether to accept or revert each change.

Key Benefits of Track Changes

- **Transparent Audit Trail:** Every insertion, deletion, and formatting change is stamped with the author's name and timestamp.
- **Non-Destructive Editing:** Edits do not overwrite existing prose permanently until explicitly accepted.
- **Targeted Review:** The document owner retains full editorial authority to approve or reject edits individually or globally.

Visual Markups Used by Writer

- **Insertions:** Newly typed text is displayed in a distinct author-specific color and is underlined.
- **Deletions:** Removed text remains visible but is displayed with a ~~strikethrough~~ line in the author's color.
- **Formatting Changes:** Font alterations or margin shifts are recorded with margin notes and indicators.
- **Comments:** Feedback notes anchored to text selections that appear in the right-hand margin area.

Step-by-Step Practical Procedures for Track Changes

A. Enabling and Disabling Track Changes

- **To Enable Recording:** Select **Edit > Track Changes > Record** (or click the *Record* icon on the Track Changes toolbar, or press `Ctrl + Shift + C`). A checkmark appears next to Record.
- **To Stop Recording:** Choose **Edit > Track Changes > Record** again to toggle the feature off.
- **To Show/Hide Markups:** Choose **Edit > Track Changes > Show** to toggle on-screen markup visibility.

B. Protecting Track Changes with a Password

To prevent unauthorized reviewers from disabling the recording feature or accepting/rejecting their own edits:

1. Choose **Edit > Track Changes > Protect...** (or click the *Protect* button on the toolbar).
2. In the *Enter Password* dialog, type a password into the **Password** field and re-enter it into the **Confirm** field.
3. Click **OK**. After protection is applied, any user attempting to turn off recording or accept changes will be prompted for this password.

C. Adding, Viewing & Deleting Comments [CBSE Board Set-4 Q.2(vi)]

- **Adding a Comment:** Select the relevant text > Choose **Insert > Comment** (or click *Insert Comment* on the toolbar, or press `Ctrl + Alt + C`). A shaded comment card appears in the **right margin area** with the author's name and date. Type your note.
- **Replying to a Comment:** Click the small downward triangle on the comment card in the margin and choose **Reply**.
- **Deleting a Comment:** Click the downward triangle on the comment card and choose **Delete Comment** (or *Delete Comment Thread / Delete All Comments*).

D. Accepting and Rejecting Changes [CBSE SQP 2024-25 Q.17]

1. Open the document and display the changes using **Edit > Track Changes > Show**.
2. Choose **Edit > Track Changes > Manage...** to open the *Manage Changes* floating window.
3. The dialog lists every tracked edit showing *Action, Author, Date & Time, and Comment*.
4. Select a change in the list to highlight it in the text:
    - Click **Accept** to keep the modification.
    - Click **Reject** to discard the modification and revert to original text.
    - Click **Accept All** or **Reject All** to approve or discard all remaining changes across the document at once.

E. Comparing Documents [CBSE SQP 2024-25 Q.3(iii)]

Used when a reviewer edited a copy of the document without enabling Track Changes, or when two separate draft versions must be cross-checked:

1. Open the **original** (unmodified) document in LibreOffice Writer.
2. Choose **Edit > Track Changes > Compare Document...** from the Menu bar.
3. In the file dialog, browse and select the **edited / revised** file and click **Open**.
4. Writer compares both files and opens the *Manage Changes* dialog, displaying all differences as recorded changes that can be accepted or rejected.

F. Merging Documents

When multiple reviewers have independently edited separate copies of the same original file, their collective suggestions can be combined:

1. Open the original document.
2. Choose **Edit > Track Changes > Merge Document...**
3. Select the revised document file. All changes from the revised file are pulled into the current document with their respective reviewer names and timestamps.

Summary of Track Changes Toolbar Icons

Activate via **View > Toolbars > Track Changes**:

- `Show Changes` — Toggles visual display of markups.
- `Record Changes` — Toggles live tracking on/off.
- `Previous / Next Change` — Steps linearly through modifications.
- `Accept / Reject` — Decides current selected change.
- `Accept All / Reject All` — Mass approves or discards all edits.
- `Manage Changes` — Opens comprehensive review panel.
- `Insert Comment` — Inserts margin note (`Ctrl + Alt + C`).
- `Protect Changes` — Sets administrative password.
- `Compare Document` — Compares against another file version.

5. Solved CBSE Board Examination Bank with Detailed Answers

Q1. State any two purposes of using Templates in a word document. [2 Marks - CBSE SQP 2022-23]

Ans:

1. **Consistency and Standardization:** Templates ensure that common design elements (logos, headers, footers, font styles, and page margins) remain identical across all organizational documents.
2. **Time Efficiency:** Authors do not need to configure page layout and styles repeatedly; they can immediately begin drafting content from a ready-made structure.

Q2. What do you understand by the term Table of Contents? List any two characteristics of a good Table of Contents in a word processor. [4 Marks - CBSE SQP 2023-24]

Ans:

Definition: A Table of Contents (ToC) is an organized list or table placed at the beginning of a document that lists chapter headings, subheadings, and section titles alongside their commencing page numbers.

Characteristics of a Good ToC:

• **Logical Hierarchy:** Clearly depicts heading levels (Level 1, Level 2, Level 3) with proper progressive indentation and typography. • Each entry acts as a clickable link allowing readers to jump directly to the referenced section. • Uses clean dotted tab leader lines to guide the reader's eye from section titles to their respective page numbers.

Hyperlinked Navigation:
Visual Alignment with Tab Leaders:

Q3. CASE STUDY: A team of writers is collaborating on a report using word processing software with Track Changes feature. Answer the following: [4 Marks - CBSE SQP 2024-25 / 2025-26]

(a) Why is the Track Changes feature essential for collaborative document editing?
Ans: It records all additions, deletions, and formatting edits made by multiple contributors non-destructively, showing exactly who made each change and when.
(b) Which menu option can be used to access this feature?
Ans: **Edit > Track Changes** (or shortcut `Ctrl + Shift + C`).
(c) Can reviewers add comments?
Ans: **Yes**, reviewers can add comments using *Insert > Comment* (`Ctrl + Alt + C`) without altering the main body text.
(d) Once changes are made by all reviewers, who can accept or reject them?
Ans: The **original author / document owner** (or designated lead editor with administrative rights/password).

Q4. (a) What is meant by exporting a template in LibreOffice Writer? How is it different from moving a template? (b) Describe the step-by-step procedure to export a template. [4 Marks - CBSE Board Set-4]
Ans:
(a) Meaning & Difference: *Exporting a template* means saving the template file from the internal LibreOffice template repository to an external folder on your computer storage or external drive as an independent `.ott` file. This differs from *moving*, which merely shifts the template between internal category folders (e.g., from *My Templates* to *Business Correspondence*) inside LibreOffice without creating an external file.
(b) Steps to Export:
1. Choose **File > Templates > Manage Templates** (or press `Ctrl + Shift + N`).
2. In the Templates dialog, locate and right-click on the template to export.
3. Choose **Export** from the context menu.
4. In the folder browser, select the destination folder on your disk and click **Select Folder**.

Q5. Rahul wants to generate a Table of Contents (ToC) in LibreOffice Writer. When he inserts the ToC, it appears completely empty. What is the most likely cause? [1 Mark - CBSE SQP]
Ans: Rahul forgot to apply heading styles (such as `Heading 1`, `Heading 2`) to his chapter titles and section headings. Writer builds the ToC based on applied heading styles, so without them, the ToC remains empty.

Q6. Krishna wants to compare his edited document with the original document. What is the first step he should take? [1 Mark - CBSE SQP 2024-25]
Ans: Krishna should open the original document first, then select **Edit > Track Changes > Compare Document...** and select the edited file.

Q7. Where does the comment box appear in LibreOffice Writer after inserting a comment? [1 Mark - CBSE Board Set-4]
Ans: In the **right-hand margin area** of the document window.